
ChurchGeniusPro

Data Deletion & Retention Policy

Combined organizational policy and adaptable template for member churches

Version 1.0

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Next scheduled review: July 1, 2027 (or upon material legal change)

Owner: Data Protection Officer / Privacy Lead

Important notice. This document is a compliance template and general information resource. It is not legal advice and does not create an attorney-client relationship. Data protection laws differ by jurisdiction and change frequently. ChurchGeniusPro and any adopting church should have this policy reviewed and tailored by qualified legal counsel before it is finalized or relied upon.

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1. Purpose and Objectives

ChurchGeniusPro (“the Company,” “we,” “us”) provides a church management platform that stores personal information about congregation members, their families, children enrolled in programs, donors, and church staff. This policy establishes how personal data is retained, when and how it is securely deleted, and how individuals can exercise their rights over that data.

The objectives of this policy are to:

- Retain personal data only for as long as it is necessary for the purposes for which it was collected, or as required by law.
- Delete, de-identify, or anonymize personal data promptly and securely once the retention period ends and no lawful basis for further retention exists.
- Honor data subject and consumer rights, including the rights to access, correct, delete, and port personal data, within the timelines set by applicable law.
- Demonstrate accountability and compliance with global and regional data protection laws.
- Give adopting churches a clear, adaptable framework they can apply to the member data they control.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all personal data processed by ChurchGeniusPro in any format (electronic or physical), across all environments (production, staging, backups, and logs), and to all employees, contractors, and sub-processors who handle such data. It covers data the Company processes on its own behalf (for example, account administration and billing) and data it processes on behalf of adopting churches (for example, member directories, contribution records, and program enrollment).

Section 17 provides a separate, adaptable template that adopting churches may use to document their own retention and deletion practices for the data they control within the platform.

3. Definitions

Personal data / personal information	Any information relating to an identified or identifiable natural person, including names, contact details, financial contribution history, and online identifiers.
Sensitive / special-category data	Data warranting heightened protection, such as data revealing religious beliefs, precise financial account details, government identifiers, health information, and data concerning children.
Controller	The party that determines the purposes and means of processing personal data. Adopting churches are generally controllers of their member data.
Processor / service provider	The party that processes personal data on behalf of a controller. ChurchGeniusPro generally acts as a processor (or “service provider” / “processor” under US state law) for church member data, and as a controller for its own account data.

Retention period	The maximum length of time a category of personal data is kept before deletion or anonymization.
Deletion	Permanent removal of personal data so that it cannot be recovered or reconstructed in the ordinary course of business.
Anonymization / de-identification	Irreversibly altering data so it can no longer be attributed to an individual; anonymized data falls outside the scope of most privacy laws.
Data subject / consumer	The individual to whom personal data relates.
Legal hold	A directive to preserve data relevant to actual or reasonably anticipated litigation, audit, or investigation, which suspends routine deletion.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Clear allocation of controller and processor responsibilities is central to lawful retention and deletion.

ChurchGeniusPro (as processor for church data):

- Processes church member data only on documented instructions from the church, including for deletion.
- Implements the technical controls that make retention limits and deletion enforceable (automated purging, secure erasure, access controls).
- Assists churches in responding to data subject requests and deletes or returns data on termination of the customer agreement.
- Maintains a current register of sub-processors and flows deletion obligations down to them.

ChurchGeniusPro (as controller for its own data):

- Determines retention periods for account, billing, security, and marketing data it collects directly.
- Appoints a Data Protection Officer or Privacy Lead accountable for this policy.

Adopting churches (as controllers):

- Decide what member data to collect, the lawful basis for it, and how long it is needed.
- Configure retention settings, respond to their members' rights requests, and issue deletion instructions.
- Obtain and document any consents required, including for children's data and communications.

5. Guiding Principles

- **Purpose limitation.** Data is collected for specified, explicit, and legitimate purposes and not further processed in incompatible ways.
- **Data minimization.** Only data that is adequate, relevant, and limited to what is necessary is collected and retained.

- **Storage limitation.** Data is kept in identifiable form only as long as necessary for its purpose or as required by law.
- **Accuracy.** Data is kept accurate and up to date; inaccurate data is corrected or erased.
- **Integrity and confidentiality.** Data is protected against unauthorized access, loss, or destruction throughout its lifecycle.
- **Accountability.** Retention decisions, deletion actions, and rights requests are documented and auditable.

6. Legal and Regulatory Framework

This policy is designed to comply with the storage-limitation, deletion, and data-subject-rights requirements of the laws below. Where laws conflict, the more protective standard is applied. Where a law requires data to be kept (for example, tax and accounting rules), that legal retention obligation overrides a deletion request for the affected records.

European Union — GDPR

The General Data Protection Regulation requires that personal data be kept in identifiable form no longer than necessary (Art. 5(1)(e), storage limitation) and grants the right to erasure / “right to be forgotten” (Art. 17), rights of access, rectification, restriction, and portability, and generally requires responses within one month.

United Kingdom — UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018

The UK regime mirrors the GDPR's storage-limitation principle and erasure rights, supervised by the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO), with the same one-month response baseline.

United States — CCPA / CPRA and state comprehensive laws

The California Consumer Privacy Act, as amended by the California Privacy Rights Act, requires businesses to disclose retention periods, to avoid retaining personal information longer than reasonably necessary, and to honor rights to delete, correct, know, and opt out, generally within 45 days (extendable by a further 45 days). As of 2026, twenty US states have comprehensive privacy laws in effect, imposing broadly similar deletion rights and, in many states, obligations to recognize universal opt-out signals. States with laws in effect include California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, Iowa, Indiana, Kentucky, Maryland, Minnesota, Montana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, New Jersey, Oregon, Oklahoma, Rhode Island, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, and Virginia. This policy applies the 45-day response baseline common to these laws.

Canada — PIPEDA

The Personal Information Protection and Electronic Documents Act requires that data be retained only as long as necessary to fulfill the identified purpose, that it be securely destroyed once no longer needed, and that access requests generally be answered within 30 days.

Children's data — COPPA and minor-specific rules

Because the platform supports children's programs (for example, Sunday School enrollment), the US Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA) and the enhanced protections for minors under the GDPR and several US state laws apply. Children's data is subject to verifiable parental consent, strict minimization, and prompt deletion once the child leaves the program or on parental request.

Other applicable laws

The Company also considers other regional data protection regimes that may apply based on where members reside (for example, Brazil's LGPD, Australia's Privacy Act, and similar frameworks), together with sector rules such as tax and charitable-contribution record-keeping requirements. New or amended laws are incorporated at the next policy review or sooner if material.

7. Categories of Personal Data

The platform processes the following broad categories of personal data:

- **Member and family profiles** — names, contact details, addresses, birth dates, gender, family relationships, and membership category.
- **Contribution and financial records** — donations, pledges, campaign giving, payment references, and year-end tax/giving statements.
- **Children's program data** — enrollment, attendance, and guardian details for Sunday School and youth activities.
- **Account and authentication data** — usernames, hashed credentials, roles, permissions, and session records.
- **Communications data** — messages, notifications, email and outreach logs, and consent records.
- **Technical and security data** — access logs, audit trails, IP addresses, and device/usage information.

8. Data Retention Schedule

The following default periods apply unless a longer period is required by law, a legal hold is in place, or an adopting church documents a different justified period. Periods run from the “retention trigger” in the final column. Financial and tax records carry statutory minimums that override individual deletion requests for those specific records.

Data category	Purpose	Default retention	Retention trigger / basis
Member & family profile data	Membership administration, directory, pastoral care	Duration of active membership + 3 years	Last activity or membership end; consent/legitimate interest
Contribution & giving records	Accounting, donor stewardship, charitable substantiation	7 years	End of tax year of the gift; tax/accounting law
Year-end tax & giving statements	Statutory donor tax documentation	7 years	End of the tax year; legal obligation
Pledge & campaign records	Campaign management and reconciliation	Duration of campaign + 7 years (financial portions)	Campaign close; tax/accounting law
Children's / Sunday School data	Program enrollment, attendance, safeguarding	Duration of enrollment + 1 year (longer only where safeguarding law requires)	Child leaves program or parental deletion request; parental consent
Account & authentication data	Access control and security	Duration of account + 90 days	Account closure; contract/legitimate interest
Communication & consent logs	Delivery records and proof of consent	24 months (consent proof kept while consent is relied upon)	Message date / withdrawal of consent

Data category	Purpose	Default retention	Retention trigger / basis
Access, audit & security logs	Security monitoring and incident response	18 months	Log creation date; legitimate interest/security
Support & correspondence	Customer and member support	24 months	Ticket closure
Marketing / outreach data	Optional communications	Until opt-out + 30 days	Withdrawal of consent
Backups	Disaster recovery	Rolling 30–90 days, then overwritten	Backup cycle; see Section 12
Billing & account (Company as controller)	Payment and legal/financial compliance	7 years	End of financial year; legal obligation

Retention periods are reviewed at least annually. Where a member's account is deleted but statutory records (such as contribution/tax records) must be retained, those records are minimized and access-restricted until their own retention period expires.

9. Data Deletion, Disposal, and Anonymization

Deletion triggers

- Expiry of the applicable retention period in Section 8.
- A valid data subject or consumer deletion/erasure request with no overriding legal basis to retain.
- Withdrawal of consent where consent was the sole lawful basis.
- Termination of a church's customer agreement (church data is deleted or returned per the agreement).
- A determination that the data is no longer necessary for its purpose.

Deletion methods

- **Secure electronic erasure.** Records are permanently removed from production databases using deletion routines that prevent ordinary recovery.
- **Anonymization.** Where aggregate or historical data has ongoing value (for example, giving trends), identifiers are irreversibly removed so the data can be retained lawfully outside the scope of privacy law.
- **Media sanitization.** Physical media is wiped or destroyed following recognized standards before disposal or reuse.
- **Backups.** Data in backups is not individually deleted on demand; it is overwritten on the normal backup cycle and is not restored to re-introduce deleted records (see Section 12).

Deletion timelines

Routine, retention-driven deletion is executed on an automated schedule. Deletion requests are completed within the statutory window for the requester's jurisdiction (see Appendix B), and in any case without undue delay. Deletion from production systems takes effect promptly; residual copies in backups are eliminated within the backup rotation cycle.

10. Data Subject and Consumer Rights

Subject to jurisdiction and limited exceptions, individuals may exercise the following rights:

- **Access / know** — obtain confirmation of processing and a copy of their data.
- **Deletion / erasure** — request deletion of their data.
- **Rectification / correction** — correct inaccurate or incomplete data.
- **Portability** — receive their data in a portable, machine-readable format.
- **Restriction / objection** — limit or object to certain processing.
- **Opt out** — of sale, sharing, targeted advertising, and certain profiling (US state laws), including via universal opt-out signals where required.
- **Withdraw consent** — at any time where processing relies on consent.
- **Non-discrimination** — not be treated adversely for exercising rights.

Requests can be submitted through the in-app privacy controls or by contacting the church (for member data) or the Company's privacy contact (for account data). Identity is verified before action. Requests are acknowledged promptly and fulfilled within the applicable statutory timeline. When a request is denied in whole or part (for example, because records must be retained for tax purposes), the requester is told why and how to appeal where an appeal right exists.

11. Children's and Minors' Data

- Children's data is collected only with verifiable parental/guardian consent and limited to what the program requires.
- It is retained only for the duration of enrollment plus a short, justified period, and deleted promptly on program exit or parental request.
- It is never used for marketing or targeted advertising, and is not sold or shared.
- Enhanced access controls restrict who can view children's records.
- Where state law provides heightened protections for minors (including teens), those stricter rules are applied.

12. Backups, Archives, and Deletion Reconciliation

Deleting a record from live systems does not instantly remove it from encrypted backups taken before the deletion. To reconcile the right to deletion with sound disaster-recovery practice, the Company: (a) removes the record from all production and active systems immediately; (b) does not use backups to restore deleted records into production; and (c) ensures the record is permanently overwritten as backups age out of the rotation (typically within 30 to 90 days). If a backup must be restored during that window, deletions are re-applied to the restored environment before it returns to service.

13. Sub-Processors and Vendor Deletion

Third parties that process personal data on the Company's behalf (for example, cloud hosting, email delivery, and payment processing) are bound by written data-processing agreements that require equivalent retention and deletion standards, restrict use of the data, and obligate secure deletion or return of data on termination. A current list of sub-processors is maintained and made available to adopting churches. Deletion instructions are propagated to relevant sub-processors.

14. International Data Transfers

Where personal data is transferred across borders, the Company relies on a lawful transfer mechanism (such as adequacy decisions, Standard Contractual Clauses, the UK International Data Transfer Addendum, or equivalent safeguards) and applies supplementary measures where necessary. Cross-border storage does not extend retention beyond the periods in this policy.

15. Legal Holds and Exceptions

Routine deletion is suspended for data subject to a legal hold arising from actual or reasonably anticipated litigation, regulatory investigation, audit, or a legal obligation to retain. Records under hold are preserved, segregated where practical, and deleted only after the hold is formally released and no other retention basis remains. Statutory retention obligations (for example, financial, tax, and safeguarding records) similarly override deletion requests for the specific records they cover, for the duration the law requires.

16. Enforcement, Governance, and Review

- The Data Protection Officer / Privacy Lead owns this policy and monitors compliance.
- Retention actions, deletions, and rights requests are logged to support accountability and audits.
- Staff and contractors receive training on retention and deletion obligations appropriate to their roles.
- Non-compliance may result in disciplinary action and, for vendors, contractual remedies.
- This policy is reviewed at least annually and whenever there is a material change in law, technology, or processing activities.

17. Template for Adopting Churches

Adopting churches are controllers of their member data and should adopt their own retention and deletion statement. The template below can be completed and approved by church leadership. Replace the bracketed placeholders and adjust periods to match local law and the church's needs, with legal counsel where possible.

[Church Name] — Member Data Retention & Deletion Statement

Effective date: [date] **Review cycle:** [annual] **Owner:** [role/name]

- 1. What we collect.** We collect [member profiles, contact details, family links, contributions, program enrollment, communications] to [administer membership, provide pastoral care, manage giving, and run programs].
- 2. Lawful basis / consent.** We rely on [consent / legitimate interest / legal obligation] and obtain verifiable parental consent for children's data.
- 3. How long we keep it.** We follow the ChurchGeniusPro default retention schedule, except: [list any church-specific periods]. Financial and tax records are kept for [7] years.
- 4. Deletion.** We delete or anonymize data when its retention period ends, when a member asks us to (subject to legal exceptions), or when a member leaves and no legal basis to retain remains.
- 5. Member rights.** Members may request access, correction, deletion, or a copy of their data by contacting [privacy contact / email]. We respond within [statutory timeline]. We do not penalize members for exercising their rights.
- 6. Children.** We keep children's program data only while the child is enrolled plus [period], and delete it promptly on request.
- 7. Contact.** Privacy questions and requests: [name, email, phone, address].

Appendix A — Data Subject Request Workflow

1. Receive	Request arrives via in-app control, email, or church contact and is logged with a date stamp.
2. Verify	Confirm the requester's identity (and parental authority for a child's data) before acting.
3. Triage	Determine request type, jurisdiction, applicable timeline, and whether any legal hold or statutory retention applies.
4. Locate	Identify the data across production systems and relevant sub-processors.
5. Action	Fulfill the request — provide, correct, port, restrict, or delete/anonymize — applying exceptions only where the law allows.
6. Respond	Notify the requester of the outcome within the statutory window; explain any denial and appeal rights.
7. Record	Retain a record of the request and action taken for accountability.

Appendix B — Statutory Response Timelines by Jurisdiction

Law / region	Standard response time	Extension
GDPR (EU/EEA)	1 month	Up to 2 additional months for complex requests
UK GDPR / DPA 2018	1 month	Up to 2 additional months for complex requests
CCPA / CPRA (California)	45 days	Additional 45 days with notice
Other US state laws	45 days (typical)	Additional 45–60 days depending on the state
PIPEDA (Canada)	30 days	Extension permitted with notice in limited cases

Reminder. This policy is a template and general information, not legal advice. Confirm current timelines and obligations with qualified counsel for each jurisdiction in which your members reside.